Teaching Statement

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Over seven years as a teaching assistant I have taught economics at every level UBC offers, from first-year principles to the PhD microeconomic theory sequence (ECON 600 and 601), which I have taught every year since 2021. In Summer 2026 I was the instructor for the department's graduate Math Camp, whose PhD sessions I designed. Teaching the PhD core, the most technically demanding material in the curriculum, alongside first-year and third-year sections has taught me to present material at the level each audience requires.

I am prepared to teach any course in the undergraduate curriculum, including macroeconomics and econometrics. My strongest interest and deepest preparation are in microeconomics, from principles through game theory, information economics, and auctions and market design, and, at the graduate level, in mathematics for economists and the microeconomic theory core. I find teaching deeply rewarding. Introducing students to economics is among the parts of academic work I value most, and I intend for it to remain central to my career.

Teaching philosophy

At a university, students lead their own learning. My role is to set out clearly what they are expected to learn and to what level, to support them through the difficult parts, and to motivate them. I do most of this through problems. In my sections the material is introduced through questions, mostly from problem sets and past exams, and we solve them together, with me calling on students as we go. A problem tied to a particular application gives students something concrete to reason about, and the points where students get stuck show them, and me, which part of the general idea they have not yet grasped. Student-led approaches have been adapted successfully even to large introductory economics courses.[1]

The same view shapes how I teach theory. In the PhD core, where proofs make up much of the material, the purpose of a proof is less to establish that a theorem holds than to show how the underlying object works, and that understanding is what later material builds on. The students I see struggle most are rarely stuck on the content of the theorems. They are unsure when and how a theorem applies, which depends on understanding the intuition behind it, and that intuition is best built by seeing the result proven from scratch.

Teaching practice

In my tutorials I present one clean, linear solution first and save alternative routes for the end, a habit I adopted after my evaluations noted, fairly, that I improvised too much. A clean solution shows students how an argument should go, and in the PhD core I also want them to recognize when one does not. For some time I have presented proofs that are correct in their approach but omit a few necessary and subtle steps, and asked students to find where the argument is incomplete. This year I have started generating flawed proofs with weaker AI models and asking students to locate the mistake. Reading a plausible argument and finding where it fails is among the most valuable skills a graduate student can take from a theory course, and lectures do not train it.

Outside the classroom, much of the learning depends on the relationship students have with me and with each other. In a class of twenty I work at making students comfortable with me, through a casual manner and an interest in their lives beyond the course, so that they will bring me even their small questions. In a large class the useful connection is among the students. In ECON 101 I put the whole section into one group chat and routed every question through it. Most were answered by classmates before I saw them, and my

[1] Denny, E. (2014), "Reinterpreting the economics textbook: A student assignment," *International Review of Economics Education* 16, 100–110.

job became confirming the answer or adding a small correction. Students who would never have emailed a teaching assistant asked freely there.

I hold office hours for one and a half to two hours a week, more before exams. When a student brings a problem, I try to reconstruct how they were thinking about it before I say anything, because the useful answer is the correct solution attached to the place where their reasoning went wrong.

Teaching large classes

Most of my teaching has been in sections of about twenty, and not every practice that works at that size survives in a lecture hall. The practice I am most confident will scale is one I have already tested in a larger class, the class-wide question channel from ECON 101. In a large ECON 101 or intermediate microeconomics (ECON 301) course I would route all questions through one moderated forum,[2] with a small amount of bonus credit for correct answers to classmates. This makes the strongest students a resource for the whole class and puts struggling students in regular contact with them, without assigned groups, whose composition is hard to get right and which students rarely welcome. My role would be to confirm answers and correct the ones that go wrong. Class time would remain devoted to lectures and worked problems, and I would keep calling on students as a problem is solved, so that a large room follows the reasoning step by step rather than receiving only the answer.

Evidence of teaching effectiveness

Course	Years	Sections	Responses	Median, /5	Good or very good
ECON 600/601 (PhD micro theory)	2021–2026	10	104	4.8–5.0	100%
ECON 514 (information and incentives)	2021	1	7	4.8	100%
ECON 101 (principles of micro)	2020, 2025	3	34	4.5–4.9	92–100%
ECON 303, 355 (intermediate micro, trade)	2019–2020	2	44	4.5–4.7	70–74%

Across the sixteen reports, an average of 96% of responding students rated my overall contribution good or very good. I received the Vancouver School of Economics Agustín Beltrán Award for Excellence in Teaching, the department's award for teaching assistants, in 2024, 2025 and 2026. Every evaluation report, along with examples of my teaching materials, is available in my online teaching dossier at william96123.github.io/teaching.

Curriculum work

I co-designed problem sets for ECON 601 over the last two years. With Jesse Perla, I designed the PhD sessions of the Math Camp, deciding together what to keep from earlier material and what to build anew, in a form the department intends to keep for future instructors. This year I am also writing up tutorial notes as a resource for future teaching assistants.

[2] Barile, L., and A. Ghosh (2026), "Understanding online peer-assisted learning with forums in the 'digital era'," *Journal of Economic Education*, published online 29 July 2026.